

Build your story. Five exercises. 45 minutes.

Your career story is the raw material for everything — your résumé, LinkedIn, cover letters, interviews, and networking conversations. Build it once. Use it everywhere.

IF YOU TAKE NOTHING ELSE AWAY

Five things that matter most

- One core story generates everything else: LinkedIn headline, résumé summary, verbal pitch, cover letter opener, gap explanation
- Most candidates write their résumé like a job description. Interviewers want to know what you actually did and what happened as a result.
- Your career moves probably make more sense than you think — when you connect them into a through-line
- The gap explanation that works is three sentences: what happened, what you learned, where you're focused
- Write your stories down first. Then let Victoria help refine them. Don't skip the writing step.

The candidates who struggle in interviews are usually not the ones with the weakest experience. They're the ones who haven't built a clear story from it.

These five exercises generate the raw material for everything in your search. Do them with a pen. Don't edit while you write — get it down first.

EXERCISE 1 — 10 MINUTES

The through-line

Every career looks random until you find the thread that connects it. Yours has one. This exercise finds it.

WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Looking across my entire career, the consistent thing I've been doing — regardless of title or company — is:
_____. *The pattern I keep returning to is:* _____. *If someone asked what I'm genuinely good at, I'd say:*
_____.

Now write one sentence that captures it: "I build [what] for [whom] by [how]." This becomes your headline.

EXERCISE 2 — 15 MINUTES

Your five best stories

Write down five things you've accomplished that you're most proud of. For each one, answer: What was the situation? What specifically did you do? What measurably happened as a result? Be specific about numbers. Revenue, headcount, percentages, time saved, costs reduced.

TEMPLATE FOR EACH STORY

Situation: _____. *What I did:* _____. *Result (with number):* _____.

NEXTCAPTER • PROOF ASSETS

These five stories become your Proof Assets — the evidence base Victoria uses to write your cover letters, tailor your résumé, and prep your interview answers. Enter them at launchyournextchapter.com

EXERCISE 3 — 5 MINUTES

Why you made the moves you made

For each career transition, write one sentence explaining why you moved. Not the version that sounds strategic in retrospect — the honest reason. You'll be asked about every transition. The honest version that makes sense is almost always more compelling than the polished one that sounds rehearsed.

EXERCISE 4 — 5 MINUTES

The gap explanation (if applicable)

If you have a gap — planned or not — write your three-sentence explanation here. What happened (one sentence, brief). What you did with the time or what you learned (one sentence). Where you're focused now (one sentence). Say it out loud five times.

TEMPLATE

"[What happened — briefly]. [What you did during that time or what changed]. I'm now focused on [specific target] because [one clear reason]."

EXERCISE 5 — 10 MINUTES

The full verbal pitch

"Tell me about yourself" is an invitation, not a biography request. Write a 90-second version that covers: where you started, what you've built, what you're best at, and what you're looking for next. Time yourself saying it. If it's over 90 seconds, cut it. If it sounds defensive or rushed, rewrite it.

STRUCTURE

I've spent [X years] [doing what, briefly]. Most recently I was [role] at [company] where I [one big accomplishment]. Before that, [one sentence on earlier career]. I'm looking for [specific next thing] because [one genuine reason].

NEXTCHAPTER · NARRATIVE BUILDER

Once you've written these exercises, bring them to Victoria. She'll generate six polished versions — résumé summary, LinkedIn About, cover letter opener, verbal pitch, gap explanation, and networking one-liner — from what you've written.